



Glimmer of hope: Unlike the 2025-26 season, the next ISL season is expected to be a full-fledged campaign with home and away fixtures. PTI

shifting bases to cut costs.

To make matters worse, the national team's poor performances — it has won just four matches in the last three years — have left an ever-decreasing fan base disillusioned.

The OCI/PIO question

In an era where many countries are embracing dual citizenship pathways to expand talent pools, that has become a major talking point, too. Ryan Williams, a former Australia Under-23 international, switched allegiance to India and scored on his senior debut, helping India secure its first win in nearly seven months in March 2026. That experiment has now become part of a wider

discussion among Indian football administrators.

Meanwhile, India's neighbour Bangladesh has already reaped the rewards of allowing dual passports, bringing in Leicester City midfielder Hamza Choudhury and US-based players Ronan and Declan Sullivan. The former helped Bangladesh beat India for the first time in 26 years, while the Sullivans contributed to its SAFF U-20 championship win this year.

India, however, does not allow overseas citizens to represent the national team unless they hold an Indian passport— typically requiring them to give up foreign citizenship, hold an OCI card for five years, and spend at least one of those years in

the country.

"For such players, at least a season in India looks like a feasible pathway, and that is something that clubs will discuss to implement," the source said. "At least one or two players of Indian origin can create a pool of 25 to 28 players, and the AIFF will also look to create its own list of a similar pool to ultimately allow such players to play for India."

Sportstar spoke to several players of Indian origin, many of whom said giving up a European passport remains a major barrier.

"There would be so many players who would want to play for India, myself included. It's just that giving up our passports and moving to India is not something most people want